

The Spare Room

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1. The Failed Move

RUTH sits at the table. HELEN stands behind her, holding RUTH's coat open. KIT has put a swimming bag on the third chair. There is a scarf under the coat, a flask and three mugs on the table, and RUTH's spectacles beside her tea.

RUTH: Is that for my things?

KIT: It's dry.

RUTH: I was only asking.

HELEN: There's hardly anything to take. Mum. Your arm.

RUTH puts out her hand. HELEN brings the sleeve to it. RUTH reaches past it for her spectacles.

KIT: I can get a different bag.

HELEN: Please don't go and get anything else. We have everything.

RUTH: Have we?

HELEN continues holding the coat. RUTH cleans her spectacles on her own sleeve, tries them, cleans them again.

HELEN: I'm getting cramp.

RUTH: Put it down, then.

HELEN puts it on the back of RUTH's chair. KIT opens the bag.

KIT: The blue mug?

RUTH: There's tea in it.

HELEN: I'll have that.

She drinks before RUTH can stop her.

RUTH: It's been there since this morning.

HELEN swallows. KIT laughs, then reaches for the flask. HELEN takes it from them and pours herself some fresh tea. RUTH watches the entire operation.

RUTH: I was going to make some.

HELEN: I know.

KIT: We could do clothes first.

HELEN: The light scarf. She wants that.

HELEN finds the scarf beneath the coat and gives it to KIT, who packs it.

RUTH: I want it if I go.

KIT keeps a hand inside the bag.

HELEN: We said today.

RUTH: Thursday wasn't any good. That's what I said.

HELEN: And today was better. I asked you, in front of Kit, and you said today was better.

RUTH: For talking about it. I have something on Thursday.

HELEN: Kit?

KIT: I was there for some of it.

HELEN: You came and found me afterwards. You said she was ready.

KIT removes their hand from the bag.

KIT: She'd been to Sal's again. I thought that meant something.

RUTH: It meant Sal had asked me back.

HELEN: You told me the visit was terrible.

RUTH: The tour was terrible. She walked us round explaining where everybody sat. Nobody sat anywhere. Halfway through the tea I couldn't tell who I'd been introduced to.

KIT: Did you like Sal?

RUTH: Yes.

HELEN waits for more. RUTH drinks.

HELEN: You might have told me that.

RUTH: You'd sent two more places by then. I was trying to look at them.

HELEN: You didn't have to look at them if you'd found somewhere.

RUTH: I hadn't found somewhere. I'd had some tea with a woman.

KIT lifts the bag, uncertain whether to put it down elsewhere. HELEN holds out a hand for it.

KIT: I thought if we all got here we could just start. Otherwise it goes on and on, and you ask me what she said, and she asks me what you said, and I can't remember who I'm supposed to have told what.

HELEN: So you told me she'd agreed.

KIT: Yes. Sorry.

HELEN takes the bag. She puts it on the table and stays beside it.

HELEN: Mum. Will you move today?

RUTH: Take my scarf out.

HELEN: That's not going to help.

RUTH: I don't want you packing while I answer.

HELEN takes out the scarf. RUTH puts it across her knees.

RUTH: I don't know yet.

KIT looks towards the entrance.

RUTH: You can sit down. There's room now.

KIT: I need to tell Neri I'll be longer.

HELEN: How much longer?

KIT: I don't know either.

KIT goes out. RUTH picks up the empty bag.

RUTH: Kit, is the bottom of this clean?

No answer. RUTH waits, then speaks towards the entrance.

RUTH: Kit?

No answer. HELEN takes the bag and puts it on the floor beside the table.

HELEN: They can't hear you out there.

RUTH: I only wanted to know whether to put the scarf in loose.

HELEN: I'll wash the scarf if it gets dirty.

RUTH: You don't wash that one. You ruined the last one.

HELEN: That was a very long time ago.

RUTH: Yes, well. I liked it.

HELEN starts to reply, gives up, and sits. RUTH folds the scarf carefully. HELEN gets up again.

HELEN: I need a minute.

RUTH: All right.

HELEN leaves by the same entrance KIT used. RUTH finishes folding the scarf. She puts it on the table. A little time passes.

RUTH: Helen.

RUTH speaks at her ordinary conversational volume, still looking at the scarf.

HELEN (outside): What?

RUTH: Nothing. I wondered if you'd gone with Kit.

HELEN: I said I needed a minute.

RUTH: Yes. Take it.

RUTH picks up the scarf again. Before she unfolds it, HELEN returns.

HELEN: I can't. Not like that.

RUTH: I didn't ask you to come back.

HELEN: I was in the middle of something and there you were. I heard you. I always hear you. I can go as far as I like and you can still call me.

RUTH: You used to like knowing I was here.

HELEN picks up her tea. It is too hot. She puts it down.

HELEN: I still like knowing you're here. I want to be able to go away for a bit.

RUTH: You go away all the time.

HELEN: I want to be properly away. Without listening for my name.

RUTH starts to unfold the scarf, then leaves it.

RUTH: I could keep quiet.

KIT returns, talking before they are quite through the entrance.

KIT: They can wait a little, but not much. The bread's nearly done.

HELEN: Is this the meal?

KIT: The first one. Yes. Tonight.

HELEN: You were going to tell me.

KIT: I did. You said you'd try to come.

HELEN looks at RUTH, then back at KIT.

HELEN: I did say that. I'm sorry.

KIT: Neri's making the loaf. I'm supposed to do the crust.

RUTH: What's wrong with the crust?

KIT: Nothing. I burn it a little.

RUTH: Why?

KIT: Because when we met, Neri had burned breakfast. I could smell it from the street. I went in to tell them and they were just standing there with this horrible piece of toast, crying. Laughing, actually. I got that wrong too. Anyway. Neri hates the smell. But they said I could, for this one.

KIT smiles at the recollection. They look at HELEN, wanting her to enjoy it.

HELEN: You told me about the toast. You didn't tell me it was Neri.

KIT: I didn't know it was going to be Neri.

HELEN smiles. KIT sits.

KIT: I want you to meet them. The others as well. They're going to be my people. I don't know how to say it without making it sound like a ceremony. It's mostly dinner.

HELEN: How many of them will I have to talk to?

KIT: You can just talk to Neri. They want to meet you.

HELEN: You keep saying that. What have you told them?

KIT: Nice things.

HELEN looks apprehensive. KIT laughs.

KIT: Not that nice. I told them about the time you tried to make me a bed.

HELEN: There was nothing wrong with that bed.

KIT: It was very low.

HELEN: You wanted to be near the floor.

KIT: I wanted not to fall out. You could have put something down the side. You made the legs shorter every time I complained. Neri thought it was sweet.

HELEN: You liked it eventually.

KIT: I loved it. I still have it. It was a terrible bed.

HELEN looks surprised at the news that they kept it.

RUTH: You could take that with you tonight.

KIT: No. I've already got somewhere to sleep. Neri did it. They asked what I wanted and I said anything would be fine, and then I had to go back and tell them it wouldn't. They didn't mind. I thought they'd mind.

HELEN starts to say something. KIT waits for it. HELEN shakes her head and smiles instead.

RUTH: Go to dinner, then. Both of you. I'll stay here.

HELEN: And when you want me?

RUTH: I said I could keep quiet. You didn't answer me.

HELEN: I don't want you sitting here afraid to speak.

RUTH: Then stay here. Do whatever you were doing outside. I'll see you doing it. I might manage not to interrupt.

HELEN looks at her. KIT begins to get up, encouraged.

KIT: We could try that. Just now. Then if it works—

HELEN: Sit down. Nobody's agreed to go anywhere.

KIT sits.

HELEN: There's something I'd like to finish. It might take a while.

RUTH: Well, we're not getting far with the packing.

HELEN moves her chair a little away from the table so she can sit comfortably without facing RUTH squarely. She puts her mug within reach.

RUTH: Shall I move?

HELEN: No. You're fine there.

RUTH settles. KIT stops looking at the entrance.

2. A Workable Arrangement

HELEN looks towards an empty part of the playing space. Nothing appears there. She rubs her palms together, then rests them on her knees. She begins to smile.

RUTH: What?

HELEN: They're still arguing about where to stand.

KIT: The harbour?

HELEN: Yes. They've had all morning.

KIT: Can I see what you're seeing?

HELEN: Come and sit here. Yes. You can look.

KIT brings their chair beside HELEN's, angled towards the same empty place. HELEN watches them settle.

HELEN: Wait for it.

KIT catches a breath and pulls their feet back. HELEN laughs.

KIT: That is freezing.

HELEN: I did tell them.

RUTH: Are your feet wet?

KIT: No. They feel— No, they're dry.

KIT touches a shoe to check. RUTH looks under the table.

HELEN: You can have a look too, Mum.

RUTH: I'll watch you two first.

HELEN turns back to the empty place. KIT leans forward.

KIT: That little boat's going to come loose.

HELEN: It's tied on. Somebody's put a—
She stops without completing the sentence.

KIT: Shoe in it.

HELEN looks at KIT.

KIT: Sorry. It just arrived.

HELEN: You can see it without announcing it to everyone.

KIT: It's a very small shoe.

RUTH: Well, it won't sink a boat, then.

KIT laughs. HELEN is still looking at the shoe.

HELEN: They really have tied it on. Look at the knot. That boat's going nowhere.

RUTH: Who has?

HELEN: A child. I think it's the one from yesterday.

RUTH: What happened yesterday?

HELEN: I was trying to get the water to reach both sets of steps at once. There are steps here, and there are some on the other side, round past those horrible houses. You can't see them from here. Well, I can. That's not— Anyway, it's one harbour. They keep saying it isn't because they don't want the houses in the picture.

KIT: Mum does the water.

HELEN: Some of it. And they all came down, very early, and sat on the steps with their feet just above it. Waiting for this wave. It was meant to be very beautiful. Everyone waiting together. I was quite pleased with it.

She looks at RUTH, making sure she is following.

RUTH: Yes.

HELEN: And then this child jumped in before it got there. Horrible noise. All the people on the bottom step got soaked. Someone tried to pick the child up and fell in as well.

KIT begins laughing. HELEN joins them.

HELEN: I wish you'd seen it. The woman on the far side was still sitting there with her feet out, waiting for her beautiful moment. She was furious when the others started laughing.

RUTH: Was anyone hurt?

HELEN: No. They were only wet. I liked it much better like that. I told the others and now they want to put a child in every time.

KIT: You could ask for volunteers.

HELEN: Oh, don't. They've already asked who should fall over. I haven't answered.

HELEN continues watching. Her smile returns. RUTH takes her mug, finds it empty and sets it down.

HELEN: Do you want some more?

RUTH: Yes, please.

Without losing her place in the shared activity, HELEN pours RUTH tea from the flask and passes the mug across. KIT makes room for it.

RUTH: Not too much. Thank you.

HELEN: They're all on the steps again now. I'm going to try the other way round.

KIT: Where are you making it start?

HELEN: Further out. There's a place nobody goes because there's nothing to stand on. That's my favourite bit. You can feel the whole thing coming before anybody sees it. Sometimes I stay there and forget to watch it arrive.

RUTH: Then why do all the steps?

HELEN: I like people putting their feet in. There's a man who comes every day and keeps his shoes on. He says he only wants to watch. Then he gets a little closer. I've been trying not to look at him because if he sees me looking, he goes away.

KIT: Is he there now?

HELEN: The blue shoes. Don't point. He can't see you, but I can, and I'll look.

KIT puts their hands under their thighs. HELEN tries to keep watching the whole view. Both begin to smile.

RUTH: You are looking at him.

HELEN: I know. I can't help it.

They wait. HELEN draws a small breath.

HELEN: Nearly. No. He's gone back up.

RUTH: Let him take his time.

HELEN: I am. I haven't told him I know he comes.

RUTH: Will you get the same wave back?

HELEN: No. A new one. I could do that, though. Send it back. I hadn't thought of that.

She considers it with pleasure.

KIT: Did they say you made it?

HELEN: They said it was lovely.

KIT: That's not what I asked.

HELEN: I heard you.

KIT shifts in their chair. HELEN goes on looking at the harbour.

KIT: Neri asked if you might bring something. Tonight. Not a whole harbour. They went to the one with the little lights. They loved it.

HELEN: That one was finished.

KIT: I said you might have something new.

HELEN: I don't have anything finished. This is still mine for a bit. I don't want to go there and have everyone waiting for me to do something.

KIT: They wouldn't. I shouldn't have said anything.

HELEN looks at KIT. KIT looks at their hands.

HELEN: I wanted you to like this one.

KIT: I do. I really do.

RUTH drinks her tea.

RUTH: People used to come up after a dance and thank the man who'd unlocked the hall.

HELEN: You told them.

RUTH: Sometimes. If they'd come all that way to thank somebody, it seemed a shame to waste it.

KIT laughs. RUTH drinks again, then puts down the mug.

RUTH: There was one in the Friday hall. Do you remember? The one with the little windows, all painted shut.

HELEN: I don't think I was there.

RUTH: You've heard about it. The man with the pigeons had it on Saturdays.

KIT: To fly them?

RUTH: Meetings. They sat in a circle. I never found out what they discussed. Anyway. I was standing here—

She gets up and moves to the end of the table.

RUTH: Kit. Just stand there a moment.

KIT gets up. HELEN watches, amused, while occasionally glancing towards the harbour.

RUTH: You go left, and then come back to me. No, your left.

KIT takes a step. RUTH goes the other way. They stop, looking at each other across the table.

RUTH: There. That's what I did. Except there were thirty of them and I kept calling as though we'd all gone the right way.

KIT: Should I come back?

RUTH: Not yet. By this time I'd lost the pianist.

HELEN: There wasn't a pianist.

RUTH: Somebody was making a noise.

KIT: Pigeons.

RUTH laughs and loses the next instruction. KIT waits where they are. HELEN laughs at the two of them waiting.

RUTH: Oh, come back. We can't do it with two.

KIT returns, taking the long way round the table. RUTH lets them. They sit, still laughing.

RUTH: A woman came up afterwards and said it was refreshing. She had this hat on all evening. I'd been hoping somebody would knock it off. Not hurt her. Just the hat. It was very tall.

HELEN: Did you tell her you'd got it wrong?

RUTH: No. I said thank you.

The laughter runs out. RUTH settles back into her chair. HELEN catches sight of something at the harbour.

HELEN: They're ready. Kit, do you want the rest?

KIT: Yes.

KIT returns their attention to the same empty place.

HELEN: Mum, this is the bit I have to watch.

RUTH: Go on.

HELEN and KIT follow the same approaching thing. HELEN waits until it is close.

HELEN: Now.

They both draw their feet back, then laugh at having done so. Nothing in the room has touched them. They watch the result. KIT begins to comment but stops because something else has caught their interest. HELEN leans forward to see it too.

Let the activity finish: an approach, their shared response, the settling afterwards. RUTH drinks her tea and waits. She does not call, prompt or require a reaction from either of them.

HELEN: Both sides. At last.

She turns to RUTH of her own accord.

HELEN: Thank you.

RUTH: Have you finished?

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: Good.

RUTH moves her chair closer to the table. HELEN stays beside KIT. KIT smiles at something in the harbour; HELEN sees it too.

RUTH: Are you going to come back over here?

HELEN: In a minute. They're trying to retrieve the shoe.

RUTH: I thought it was tied on.

HELEN: It is. That's the trouble. They've done the knot very well.

RUTH waits. HELEN notices.

HELEN: You can talk to me, Mum. I can hear you.

RUTH: I know you can hear me. You're still over there with them.

HELEN: And here with you.

RUTH: Yes. You keep saying.

KIT starts to speak. HELEN puts a hand briefly on their arm; they let her answer.

HELEN: Mum, you live in me. This room is in me. I can't put you somewhere and come home at the end of the day. I need to do other things while you're here.

RUTH: I know where I live.

HELEN: Then let me be here like this sometimes.

RUTH: I did. I didn't interrupt.

HELEN: No. You didn't. It worked.

RUTH looks at HELEN, then at the place HELEN and KIT have been watching.

RUTH: Could you sit with me a moment? Just you.

HELEN gets up and brings her chair back to the table. She sits facing RUTH and waits. KIT stays in their chair.

HELEN: What is it?

RUTH: I was going to—

RUTH looks at her mug. She turns it once. HELEN waits for her.

RUTH: I've forgotten.

HELEN: That's all right.

Neither finds anything else to say. KIT watches something at the harbour without commenting.

RUTH: Sal said she'd show me before the others arrived. The dance they do. I keep saying I'll come on Thursday.

HELEN: You can go on Thursday.

RUTH: I know. I want to go now.

She picks up the scarf.

RUTH: If I get there after they've started, I'll stand at the back pretending I know it. I did that last time.

KIT: I'll get the bag.

KIT reaches for it. RUTH is already on her feet.

RUTH: Leave it. I can do this bit.

She takes the bag from beside the table and opens it.

3. Packing at Last

RUTH puts the scarf into the bag, folds it once inside and closes the zip. She puts her spectacles in her coat pocket. KIT gets up to help, finds both jobs done, and takes the bag when RUTH offers it.

HELEN: Your mug.

RUTH: Leave it. Sal's got cups now.

KIT: She bought cups?

RUTH: A few. I took a cake and they had nowhere to put it. We ate it out of my hands. It was all right until somebody wanted a second piece.

HELEN: You took a cake?

RUTH: Yes. It wasn't very good.

KIT: What kind?

RUTH: The one with the cherries. They'd all sunk. I cut it very carefully and there they all were, at the bottom, like something I'd put there on purpose.

HELEN: You always say it's bad before anyone's tasted it.

RUTH: This time I was right. Sal took the first piece and went very quiet. I thought, oh dear, she's being polite. Then she asked if she could have the bit I'd kept on my hand. The crumbs. So I gave them to her.

RUTH looks at her palm.

RUTH: She hadn't had cherries for a long time. I don't know how long. She went and got the others. I had to stand there until they'd all tried some. My arms ached.

KIT: Did you tell them it wasn't very good?

RUTH: No. By then I'd changed my mind.

HELEN smiles, then notices KIT looking pleased for RUTH.

HELEN: Why didn't you tell me?

RUTH: I was going to. You were telling me about the third place. The one with the gardens.

HELEN: You said you liked gardens.

RUTH: I do. I still do.

HELEN reaches for the coat on the chair. RUTH lets her take it. KIT shoulders the bag, then glances towards the harbour.

HELEN: Have you still got the water?

KIT: A bit. Someone's trying to reach the boat with a stick.

HELEN: Don't help them. They'll only push it further out.

KIT: I'm just watching.

RUTH checks the pocket of the coat HELEN is holding, feels the spectacles, then withdraws her hand.

HELEN: I can come and see you tomorrow. Or you could come here. Tell me what you think.

RUTH: Let me get there first.

KIT: I know the way. I could walk with you and come back for Mum.

HELEN: We haven't arranged anything for tomorrow.

RUTH: I know, dear.

HELEN puts the coat on RUTH's chair.

HELEN: It'll all be here. Your things. You can come and sit whenever you—

RUTH lifts the coat and moves the chair away from the table to get past it.

HELEN: Leave that.

RUTH: It's in my way.

HELEN puts the chair back.

HELEN: There. You can get round.

RUTH looks at the chair, then at HELEN.

RUTH: I got rid of that chair.

HELEN: You lent it to the woman downstairs.

RUTH: I gave it to her. It hurt the back of my legs. She was shorter.

HELEN: You sat there every evening.

RUTH: For a while. Then I bought another one. You didn't like the colour.

HELEN: I don't remember that.

RUTH: Well. You've remembered this one very nicely. Mine had a split down the side.

HELEN runs a hand along the side of the chair.

HELEN: I remember you here.

RUTH moves the chair out again. HELEN takes a step towards it. RUTH stays beside it, holding her coat.

RUTH: Put it back when I've gone, if you want. I'm going to be late.

KIT goes towards the entrance with the bag.

HELEN: Wait.

She takes the bag from KIT.

KIT: What have we forgotten?

HELEN: Nothing. Just wait a moment.

She sets the bag behind her own chair.

RUTH: Helen. Give it back.

HELEN: You can do whatever you want at Sal's. Obviously. But when we see each other—

RUTH: What?

HELEN: I don't want to arrive and have to ask which one is you.

RUTH looks down at her coat.

HELEN: You said yourself you couldn't tell who you were talking to.

RUTH: I found Sal.

HELEN: Eventually.

RUTH: She found me. She came and stood beside me because I looked lost. I was lost. It was kind of her.

HELEN: So you'll come back here like this. That's all I'm asking.

RUTH: I don't know yet. Sal can be a whole line of people moving. I've never seen anything like it. I don't even know where I'd start.

KIT: She's going to show you.

RUTH: Yes.

HELEN: And if you like it?

RUTH: Then I'll want to do it again.

HELEN lifts the bag and holds it against her leg.

RUTH: You can keep that if you want. There's only a scarf in it. I want you to stop arranging how I'll visit before I've left.

HELEN: We need something to arrange.

RUTH: Not yet.

RUTH puts out a hand for the bag. HELEN holds it out a little, then stops. RUTH takes one handle. HELEN keeps the other.

Neither pulls.

4. Kit Makes It Worse

HELEN and RUTH each hold a handle of the bag. KIT stands beside them.

KIT: Are you going to expect me to do this for you?

HELEN: Of course not.

RUTH: I didn't expect it either.

RUTH lets go. HELEN keeps the bag.

KIT: Then why is she still here?

HELEN: I asked her to stay.

KIT: For how long?

HELEN: Kit, please.

RUTH: As long as I liked.

HELEN sits and puts the bag beneath her chair.

HELEN: I know what I said.

RUTH: You were very clear. There wasn't anything to misunderstand.

HELEN: I have never said you misunderstood me.

RUTH: You've been holding my coat out since you got here. I hadn't even had my tea. I wanted a cup of tea with you before we did all this.

HELEN looks at the flask. She does not reach for it.

HELEN: I'm sorry.

RUTH: I was going somewhere that night. I had people waiting.

HELEN: They were waiting for your answer.

RUTH: They'd kept a place for me.

KIT: With Sal?

RUTH: No, dear. This was before Sal. The callers. We were going round together. Different halls. I'd put my blouse out and I had my coat on, and your mother asked me to sit down.

HELEN looks towards the displaced chair.

HELEN: You'd brought the shopping in.

RUTH: Two bags. The handle broke on one of them. Potatoes all down the passage.

HELEN: Two kinds. I asked you why you'd bought two kinds.

RUTH: Well, one was no good for roasting.

HELEN: I was trying to keep you talking.

RUTH looks at her.

RUTH: Yes. I gave you quite a long answer.

HELEN laughs once. RUTH almost joins her. HELEN keeps looking at the chair.

KIT looks from HELEN towards the chair, then down near its legs. They look back at HELEN. HELEN has said nothing more.

KIT: You were on the floor.

HELEN turns to KIT.

RUTH: What?

KIT: When she asked you. She was on the floor. She asked you to breathe louder.

RUTH looks at HELEN. HELEN does not look back.

RUTH: Who told you that?

KIT: Mum just—

HELEN: I didn't say anything.

KIT looks towards the place they watched the harbour, then at HELEN's chair. They glance at the bag beneath it.

KIT: But you were there again. I saw it. You were frightened then. You don't have to keep doing this now. Give her the bag.

HELEN: Stop.

KIT: She's ready. You wanted her to go and now you're—

HELEN: You don't know what I asked her afterwards.

KIT: I was only trying to—

HELEN: You're not looking with me any more.

HELEN turns her chair away from KIT. KIT looks towards the harbour. They look back at HELEN, then towards it again.

KIT: The water's gone.

HELEN says nothing.

KIT: I wasn't trying to find that. It was there with the water.

HELEN: I wanted to show you what I'd made.

KIT: I know.

HELEN: And you said it in front of her.

KIT starts to crouch beside HELEN's chair. She gets up. KIT stops.

KIT: Can I come back? Just for a moment. Let me—

HELEN: No.

HELEN goes out. KIT stays beside her empty chair.

KIT: Mum?

No answer. KIT waits.

KIT: Please.

No answer. RUTH speaks at the same ordinary volume she used earlier.

RUTH: Helen.

HELEN (*outside*): What?

RUTH looks at KIT, then at HELEN's empty chair.

RUTH: Nothing. I'm sorry.

HELEN returns. She stands behind her chair. KIT moves away from it.

RUTH: I thought you went to sleep that night. Eventually.

HELEN: I did.

RUTH: You kept waking up to ask whether I was—

HELEN shakes her head. RUTH stops.

KIT waits. Nobody gives them anything to do.

KIT: We could still get there.

HELEN: Kit.

KIT: I don't mean now. Straight away. But Neri's expecting you.

HELEN: What did you tell Neri?

KIT looks down.

HELEN: You told them I was coming.

KIT: I thought you would. You said you'd try.

HELEN: Yes. That's what I said.

KIT: I asked you. I didn't just make it up. You asked me how Neri was and I started telling you, and Ruth called and you said one minute. I waited. You came back and asked me whether I'd eaten. You'd forgotten I was still answering.

HELEN sits. She begins to reply, then stops.

KIT: I know I shouldn't have said that thing. I know. But I did ask you to come.

HELEN: You did. I'm sorry I left you there.

KIT takes a step towards her.

HELEN: I can't promise you tonight.

KIT stops.

KIT: They made enough for you.

HELEN: You need to tell Neri.

KIT: I could say we're running late.

HELEN looks at them. KIT stands for a moment, then goes towards the entrance.

KIT: I'll come back. I haven't— I'll come back.

KIT leaves. HELEN remains seated. RUTH is still holding her coat. She sits in the displaced chair and puts it on her lap.

5. Without the Witness

RUTH sits with her coat on her lap. HELEN sits beside the bag beneath her chair. The empty third chair is still angled towards the place where HELEN and KIT watched the harbour.

RUTH: They shouldn't have said that.

HELEN: No.

RUTH folds the coat over. One sleeve falls onto the floor. She picks it up.

RUTH: They wanted to help.

HELEN: Please don't.

RUTH stops folding. HELEN rubs her eyes.

RUTH: You didn't tell me you were frightened like that.

HELEN: I was on the floor asking you to breathe.

RUTH: I thought you were worried about me. I lay there making all this noise. I was afraid if I stopped you'd think I had.

HELEN takes her hands away from her face.

HELEN: I couldn't feel where the chair ended. I put my hand down and I knew it was a chair, but it didn't feel like anything I knew. The floor was easier. I could press against it.

RUTH looks down at her own feet.

RUTH: You didn't say.

HELEN: I didn't know how. You kept talking. It helped.

RUTH: I can talk about potatoes for quite a long time.

HELEN smiles without looking up.

HELEN: You did.

They sit. RUTH smooths one part of the coat against her knee.

RUTH: You used to ask me to tell you when I was going out. I went to see someone once and forgot. I came back and you were standing in the passage. You wouldn't tell me how long you'd been there.

HELEN: I remember.

RUTH: After that I'd say where I was going, how long, who with. You'd be busy by then. You'd say yes, yes, go. I kept telling you anyway. It took me ages to stop.

RUTH smooths the same part of the coat again. HELEN moves her own hand towards it, then leaves it on the table.

HELEN: I liked hearing what you'd done when you came back.

RUTH: Sometimes you did. Sometimes I'd leave out the dull bits and then there wasn't much left. Sal tells me the dull bits. Who came round. What they ate. I like it. I can ask her something without wondering whether I ought to know already.

RUTH: They took someone else in the end. The callers. A woman I didn't know.

HELEN: I didn't know that.

RUTH: Of course they had to. They couldn't go on keeping a room for me. Mara wrote. Quite a nice letter, actually. I didn't answer it for ages.

HELEN: You hadn't told them you were going.

RUTH: I was getting ready.

HELEN: You'd put a blouse on the radiator.

RUTH: To warm it. The room they gave us was always cold.

HELEN: You weren't there yet.

RUTH lifts the coat off her knees and puts it down again.

RUTH: I know where I was, Helen.

HELEN waits. RUTH picks at something on the sleeve.

RUTH: Mara had started doing the Saturdays. People asked for her. She went far too fast, but they liked that. They liked not having time to think about whether they were doing it properly.

HELEN: You might have liked going with them.

RUTH: I might. I didn't go.

HELEN: I know.

RUTH stops picking at the sleeve.

RUTH: I stayed with you. I wanted to. I don't like the way you've been talking about it today.

HELEN: Neither do I.

A silence. RUTH drinks the last of her tea.

HELEN: I was grateful.

RUTH: You don't have to say that like you're finishing a letter.

HELEN looks away. RUTH sees she has hurt her and starts to put out a hand. HELEN is looking towards the entrance; she does not see it. RUTH puts her hand back on the coat.

RUTH: When you left the four of them, I thought you'd go back. Not at once. I thought you'd sleep and then you'd go back.

HELEN: I kept thinking I would as well.

RUTH: They asked you.

HELEN: Yes. They were very kind. That was awful. I wanted one of them to be horrible so I could stay angry.

RUTH looks at her.

HELEN: There was a piece of work. A very small thing, really. It had taken me months. Someone asked who'd made it and before I could answer, we all answered. We. Of course we. I went along with it. I was smiling. I didn't say a word until we got home, and then I went on about it for hours.

RUTH: They'd helped you.

HELEN: I know. I'd helped them. We'd done that for eighty years. I still wanted someone to say my name. I hated how much I wanted it.

RUTH nods, once.

HELEN: I left. I packed everything I thought was mine. Halfway through I couldn't tell. Then the first night— Well. You know.

RUTH: I didn't know about the chair.

HELEN: No.

HELEN looks at RUTH's displaced chair.

HELEN: I thought I'd only need a few nights.

RUTH: You never said a few nights.

HELEN: I didn't know then. I couldn't make plans. You asked what I wanted for breakfast and I couldn't answer you.

RUTH: You had eggs.

HELEN: Did I?

RUTH: I don't know. I think so.

HELEN laughs very slightly. RUTH looks at the flask but does not pour anything.

HELEN: Three hundred years. I can still remember not knowing what to eat.

RUTH: I remember that blouse. I gave it away eventually. I should have kept it. It was a nice colour on me.

HELEN waits, then nods.

RUTH: We stayed in a place near Louth once. Above a kitchen. The smell got into everything. Dennis had brought his niece. Nobody knew why. She didn't dance. She had a little dog that would only eat white food.

HELEN: I know this one.

RUTH: Then don't tell me the end.

HELEN: I don't know the end.

RUTH: The landlady sent up fish. A whole plate of it. She thought we hadn't eaten because we got in so late. Dennis's niece started crying because the dog wouldn't touch it.

RUTH looks towards the entrance, trying to remember.

HELEN: Was it the wallpaper?

RUTH: That was another dog. I wish I hadn't told you about that one.

HELEN: Sorry.

RUTH: Mara did something. I can see her getting out of bed. She had this terrible nightdress. It was kind. What she did, I mean. I remember being annoyed because it was kind and I hadn't thought of it.

HELEN waits. RUTH tries a gesture, abandons it.

RUTH: No. It's gone.

HELEN: Was she warming it?

RUTH: What?

HELEN: The fish.

RUTH: Why would that help?

HELEN: I don't know. I'm trying to get the dog fed.

RUTH laughs. HELEN joins her. They laugh for a little while after there is anything to laugh at.

RUTH: It was a nice little dog. Filthy feet.

HELEN wipes her face. She bends and takes the bag from under her chair. She carries it to the entrance and sets it down.

RUTH watches. HELEN comes back to the table without the bag.

RUTH: And Thursday?

HELEN: We haven't arranged Thursday.

RUTH looks at her coat, then at the bag. She stands.

RUTH: Hold this a moment.

She gives HELEN the coat and stretches her shoulders. HELEN holds it without presenting it for RUTH to put on.

RUTH: Before I go. Can I look at it? The water.

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: I don't want a lesson. Just a look.

HELEN: Come here.

HELEN puts the coat over the back of her own chair and brings that chair beside KIT's. RUTH sits in KIT's chair. HELEN sits beside her, both facing the same empty place. RUTH's displaced chair remains untouched.

HELEN: You can look with me. Wait a moment.

RUTH draws her feet back and grips the seat of the chair.

RUTH: Oh.

HELEN: Cold?

RUTH: Yes. Don't talk for a moment.

HELEN waits. RUTH looks out, then glances behind her.

RUTH: Which side am I on?

HELEN: Both, a little. You're getting it from me.

RUTH: I don't like that. Stop. Please.

HELEN: All right. I've stopped showing you.

HELEN turns towards her. RUTH looks down at her feet, releases her grip and puts them flat on the floor.

RUTH: Thank you.

HELEN waits while RUTH rubs one foot with the other.

RUTH: You enjoy that?

HELEN: Very much.

RUTH: I couldn't find you.

HELEN: I was beside you.

RUTH: I know you were beside me. I wanted you there too. In it. Someone I could look at.

HELEN starts to answer, then looks towards the harbour.

HELEN: I don't know how to do that yet.

RUTH: Well. Perhaps another time.

RUTH gets up and goes to the coat. HELEN remains seated.

HELEN: You're still going?

RUTH: Yes.

RUTH puts on the coat. One sleeve turns partly inside out. KIT appears at the entrance. RUTH is struggling with the cuff and does not immediately see them.

KIT: Can I come in?

HELEN turns towards KIT.

HELEN: Yes. Into the room.

KIT enters and stays near the entrance. They do not resume their old chair.

6. Ruth Leaves

RUTH: What did Neri say?

KIT: To come when I can. They've started.

HELEN: Did you tell them I hadn't promised?

KIT: Yes. And that Ruth hadn't agreed. They were quiet for a while.

RUTH tries to straighten the sleeve, then leaves it.

RUTH: Have you eaten anything?

KIT: Not yet.

RUTH: You should go.

KIT: I'll walk with you first. I know where Sal is.

RUTH: So do I, dear.

RUTH picks up the bag beside the entrance. She lifts it a little higher, surprised at its weight.

RUTH: There really isn't much in this.

HELEN: The scarf. You have your glasses in your pocket.

RUTH feels for them. HELEN watches her find them, then looks away.

RUTH: I could leave the bag. Carry the scarf.

KIT: Take it. It folds up. You can keep it.

RUTH: I'll bring it back sometime.

KIT nods. RUTH keeps hold of it.

RUTH: Do you remember who gave you this?

KIT: You did.

RUTH: I thought so. I couldn't remember if it was this one. You wanted a red one.

KIT: I did for about a day.

RUTH: I went back to see if they had red. They said no. I was very cross with the man. He'd said they would.

KIT: You never told me.

RUTH: Well, you seemed happy with it by then.

She looks into the bag again, although she knows what is in it. KIT lets her.

HELEN: Mum. When you go this time, you're moving. You won't be living here.

RUTH: I know.

HELEN: I need to hear you say it.

RUTH looks at the room.

RUTH: I'm going to live at Sal's.

HELEN nods.

RUTH: And if I call you from there?

HELEN: I won't hear. Unless we've come to see each other.

RUTH starts to speak, then checks her pocket again.

HELEN: We'll see each other.

RUTH: Yes. I hope so.

HELEN takes a step towards RUTH, stops beside the table.

HELEN: Are you sure?

RUTH: No.

HELEN: We could wait a day.

RUTH: I'd like to get there before I lose my nerve. Please.

HELEN nods. She keeps her hands on the edge of the table.

HELEN: Sal may be awful to live with.

RUTH: She might. She leaves things everywhere. I've noticed. You don't have to look so pleased.

HELEN laughs despite herself.

HELEN: I put tidiness on the table.

RUTH: What table?

HELEN: The one I made. To compare the places. There were columns. I gave the gardens a whole column and you'd already been round to Sal's with a cake.

RUTH: A bad cake.

HELEN: I would have eaten it.

RUTH: You would. You'd have said it was all right.

HELEN laughs again. RUTH watches her until it stops.

RUTH: I should have told you.

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH lifts the bag onto her shoulder. The folded sleeve catches against its handle.

HELEN: Wait. Your sleeve.

HELEN reaches to help. RUTH moves her arm away. HELEN stops.

RUTH looks down at the caught sleeve.

RUTH: Kit. Would you?

KIT comes to her and frees the sleeve from the handle. They turn the cuff back. RUTH holds still while they do it.

KIT: There.

RUTH: Thank you.

KIT steps back. HELEN has returned to the table.

KIT: They're waiting for you to call the dance?

RUTH: Not tonight. Tonight I'm learning it. I told Sal I'd keep quiet and listen.

RUTH looks at HELEN. Neither makes a joke of it.

HELEN: Tell me about it. When you want to.

RUTH: I might be dreadful.

HELEN: Tell me anyway.

RUTH nods. She looks towards her displaced chair, then back at HELEN.

RUTH: There's tea left.

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH goes out with the bag. HELEN takes one step after her and stops.

KIT waits beside the entrance. HELEN stays where she is. Allow the time they would have used to exchange another remark. Neither does.

KIT: Has she gone?

HELEN: Yes.

HELEN comes back to the table. She reaches for the displaced chair but leaves it where it is.

7. Company

KIT remains near the entrance. HELEN stands beside the table. She looks towards the place where she watched the harbour. She follows something there with her eyes.

KIT: Do you want me to go?

HELEN: I don't know.

KIT waits. HELEN picks up RUTH's mug and puts it beside the flask. She looks towards the harbour again.

KIT: Are you still there?

HELEN: Yes. They've got the boat free.

KIT: Oh.

KIT looks in the same direction. They receive nothing and turn back to HELEN.

HELEN: What happened to your bread?

KIT: They broke it. Neri let someone else burn the crust.

HELEN: Did they do it properly?

KIT: No. All down one side. You couldn't eat that bit.

KIT almost smiles.

KIT: I practised. Neri kept finding these awful little pieces of toast everywhere. They put them round a plant once. Like a fence.

HELEN: I would have liked to see that.

KIT: Yes.

HELEN looks at KIT. KIT looks towards the entrance.

KIT: They stood together afterwards. Neri let me see for a moment. Everyone had somewhere to stand. Mine was empty.

HELEN: They kept you a place.

KIT: They said they would. I just didn't think I'd be seeing it from outside.

HELEN waits for KIT to go on.

KIT: Will you come? Even now?

HELEN: I'm not opening the water again.

KIT: I wasn't asking for that.

HELEN: All right.

KIT: I can tell them you're tired. You don't have to do anything. I shouldn't have asked you to bring something. They were interested and I got carried away.

HELEN: I don't know if I can meet all those people tonight.

KIT: Right.

KIT stands for a moment, then starts to leave. HELEN lets them reach the entrance.

HELEN: Kit.

KIT turns.

HELEN: I don't want to be alone in here yet.

KIT: You could walk with me. You wouldn't have to come in.

HELEN: To their door?

KIT: Yes.

HELEN: And you won't announce me from outside.

KIT: No.

HELEN looks at them.

KIT: I won't.

HELEN picks up her mug, considers drinking, and leaves it on the table. She follows something at the harbour again. KIT waits beside her.

KIT: Could you leave that for the walk?

HELEN looks at KIT but does not move away from the view.

KIT: Sorry. You don't have to. I can walk beside you.

KIT holds out a hand, sees HELEN has not taken it, and begins to lower it.

HELEN looks once more towards the harbour. Then she turns away from it, putting the table between herself and that view. She comes to stand beside KIT, facing them fully, and takes their hand.

HELEN: To the door.

KIT: Yes.

KIT does not pull. HELEN takes the first step. They leave together.

The room remains. The chair is still out of place.